

hat. George was a man of modest means; he and Georgette used public transportation, as owning a car was a great luxury in those days. As their relationship progressed, they took long walks by the ocean and frequented ethnic restaurants to soak up the local flavor—but they didn't spend on anything fancy during their courtship. George didn't try to impress my mother with lavish dinners or extravagant gifts he could not afford. Even in those early days, Georgette was vetting her future husband, whether she was aware of it or not—and he was passing the test. Their courtship assured her that they could both be happy even during lean economic times.

The two of them had long conversations about every detail of their proposed partnership, including their goals regarding money, family and quality of life. My mother was adamant that Shane and I get to know George before she married him; if any red flags or serious issues had surfaced, I have no doubt she would have pulled the plug. Fortunately for all of us, George had a natural aptitude as a father and as a provider, which he continues to demonstrate to this day. I now think of George as my father, and indeed, he is (but more on that later).

My mother financed the wedding, a simple yet tasteful affair with about 20 guests. Once George became the breadwinner, he made it abundantly clear that Georgette's money was her own; he had no interest in how much she had or how she spent it. While Terry had been threatened by the fact that my mother had her own funds and accounts, George encouraged her financial independence. My mother had found a life partner who had the same money values and a shared understanding of how financial independence works within a marriage. They weren't idealistic kids drinking the Kool-Aid of romantic love. George and Georgette saw marriage as a contract: two people coming together to build a dynasty, one based on emotional closeness, but one that doesn't exclude financial prudence.

Why am I telling you this story? Because if you want a partnership and dynasty that last, take a cue from my mother. Love, marriage and kids can provide some of the richest rewards in life—but only if you have a strong financial foundation to support them.